rocket systems – were struggling to harness their obstinate camels. In Hansi, Colonel James Skinner was attempting to call up his reserves from the flooded pasturelands of Haryana while orderlies polished the rusting helmets and chain mail of the troopers. In Meerut and Roorkee the cantonments were awash with mud as the Company sepoys packed up their kit and began the march up the Grand Trunk Road towards Karnal and Ferozepur, their bedraggled wives and mistresses streaming through the quagmire behind them.

Leading one regiment through the monsoon mud was William Nott, a plainspoken yeoman farmer's son from the Welsh borders who had arrived in India forty years earlier, fresh from Caernarvon, and had slowly worked his way up to become one of the most senior Company generals in India. He and his sepoys – 'the fine manly soldiers' to whom he was fiercely attached – struggled up the road to Karnal from their base in Delhi where he had just buried his 'beloved and lamented Letitia', his wife of twenty years. 'The road was covered with troops, guns, gun-carriages, ammunition and treasure,' he wrote. 'It required patience in man and horse to wend their way between these hackeries and implements of war.'

If younger soldiers were hoping the war might bring them glory, plunder and promotion, Nott merely hoped it would help him forget. 'Passed a miserable day in thinking of times gone by, and those I dearly love,' he wrote to his daughters the night of his arrival in Karnal. He added: 'strange to say, my mind was in some degree relieved' by the distraction of a war to be fought; only for him to be horrified by this thought and scribble in the margin: 'When will man cease to destroy his fellow man?'[11]

It came as little comfort that he had finally been promoted to major-general, a distinction that might have come much earlier had he not been so quick to speak truth to power. For Nott was not a man to keep quiet in the face of a perceived slight, and he was already gearing up to take offence at the precedence that was being given to newly arrived commanders of the British army. These men, though usually richer and better connected than their counterparts in the army of the Company, did not speak Hindustani or have any experience of fighting in India or with sepoys. He had heard rumours that the Commander-in-Chief, Sir John Keane, was to take several sepoy regiments away from the control of the Company's generals, and he was already squaring up for a fight about the issue. 'The truth is he is a Queen's officer, and I am a Company's,' he explained to his daughters. 'I